

THE HOLD-UP

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

HOLD-UP LESSON

The hold-up play is one of the first techniques bridge players learn, right up there with finessing. And the first example they are shown will be something like this one.

You are playing a notrump contract.

Your Left Hand Opponent leads the ♥5 and RHO puts on the ♥Q.

Here is the ♥ suit in dummy's and your hands.

Dummy ♥ 8 4

You ♥ A 10 2

Suppose you take your ♥A at the first (or second) trick. Then, whenever you lose a trick to either opponent they will win some ♥ tricks, four of them if LHO has led a 5-card suit.

But suppose you refuse to win your ♥A until the third round; you hold-up. Then, whenever you lose a trick to your RHO he may be void in ♥s because he started out with just three of them. Since he cannot lead a ♥ back to his partner your contract may be successful.

Of course, even after the hold-up, if you lose a later trick to your LHO he will then cash his ♥ tricks. So hold-up plays aren't always perfect solutions.

The Basic Hold-up:

Look at that ♥ suit in a full example.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5. East plays ♥Q.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ 5 4 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ A 10 2
♦ Q 6 3
♣ A K 10 6

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 5.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.

The danger is that West may hold five ♥s, so when you drive out the ♦A, the defense may be able to win 4 ♥ tricks to go along with their 1 ♦.

So you hold-up your ♥A until the third round. Then you play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes the ♦A. If it is East who wins, and he started with only 3 ♥s, he will have none to return to his partner's hand. And if East does happen to have a fourth ♥ it means the ♥ suit was originally 4-4 and you will only lose 3 tricks in the suit..

Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.
East plays the ♥A and returns the ♥9.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ K J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 6.

You need 3 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit will provide them.
Once East takes the ♥A on the first round the situation becomes identical to the first example.
You hold-up your ♥K until the third round. Then you drive out the ♦A and hope it is East who has it.

Not Holding Up with a King

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♥5.
East plays the ♥J.

♠ A 7 3
♥ 8 4
♦ A J 10 9 8
♣ Q J 2

♠ K 8 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ Q 6 5 3
♣ A K 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 ? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

The opening lead guarantees you a ♥ trick.
And you'd better take it right now or East will return a ♥ and West will take all the ♥ winners he happened to be dealt.

This was not a time to hold up, and after you win the first trick you pin all your hopes on the ♦ finesse. If West holds the ♦K you will make the contract. If East holds the ♦K they are going to bury you with ♥s.

Holding Up with A J x: or not:

When your LHO leads a suit in which you hold A J x and RHO plays a high honor, you have an interesting situation. This holding might be just one stopper, but might be two, depending on which defender will be getting the lead.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will take his ♠ winners.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through East. If the finesse fails West will not be able to lead ♠s without setting up your ♠J.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♠6.
East plays the ♠Q.

♠ 7 3
 ♥ A 8 4 3
 ♦ A 6 5 3
 ♣ K Q 2



♠ A J 2
 ♥ K 6 2
 ♦ Q J 10 9
 ♣ A 7 5

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 1? : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 7.

Suppose you take your ♠A at trick one.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will lead a ♠ through your ♠J 2 and West will win a lot of ♠s.

Suppose you hold-up your ♠A until the third round.

You need tricks from ♦s and you must finesse through West. If the finesse fails East will be unable to return a ♠ to his partner (unless they split 4-4).

Holding Up with Two Stoppers:

If you have to establish a suit which is missing two top honors then you may have to hold-up on their suit when you have it double-stopped.

The contract is 3NT and West's opening lead is the ♦J.
East plays the ♦K.

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ A 7 3
♥ A 8 3
♦ 6 5 2
♣ J 10 9 6

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 0 : Total = 7.

You need to get 2 tricks from ♣s. The danger is that West may have a 5-card ♦ suit that can be established before you can set up any ♠ tricks.

Suppose you take your ♦A at trick one and play on ♣s. If the two high ♣s are split, East will win the first ♣ and play another ♦, allowing West to establish the suit. When you again play ♣s, WEST will take his winner and also take some ♦s.

Suppose you allow East to win the ♦K. He will return the suit and drive out one of your stoppers, but he will use his last remaining ♦ to do so. Now, whenever East takes his ♣ winner he will have no ♦s to help West establish the suit. Since West has only one entry in ♣s he can win it and establish the ♦s, but won't be able to get back in to cash them.


♠ K Q 2
♥ K 6 2
♦ A Q 3
♣ Q 7 5 4

Holding Up at a Suit Contract:

The hold-up is utilized most often when you are playing notrump; the purpose usually being to disrupt communications between the defenders by exhausting one defender of his partner's suit. This use of a hold-up doesn't really apply to suit contracts.

There are other reasons for a hold-up, though, which do apply in suit contracts.

The contract is 4♥ and West's opening lead is the ♠3.
East plays the ♠Q.

Since this is a suit contract count your losers.

♠ 8 7
♥ Q 10 8 3
♦ K 7 5
♣ A J 9 4

♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

You can't avoid losing 1 ♠, and the ♦A is also a sure loser. If the ♣ finesse works you would be home free, but even if it fails you can guarantee the contract with a hold-up play.

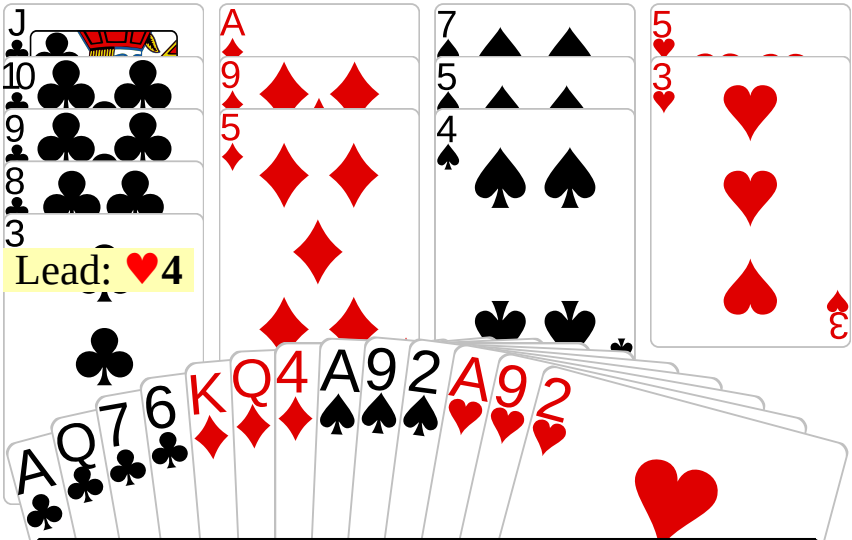
The danger is that if East holds the ♦A, West may obtain the lead and play a ♦ through dummy's ♦K, giving you two ♦ losers. You can prevent that from happening if you can prevent West from getting the lead. Since the only suit West can get the lead with is ♠s, all you have to do is let East win the ♠Q and take your ♠A on the second round.


♠ A 6 2
♥ A K J 6 2
♦ 8 6
♣ Q 10 3

Since East cannot attack ♦s from his side he will have to give you the lead. You pull trumps, then finesse the ♣. Even if the finesse loses East cannot play ♦s without setting up dummy's ♦K, so you will eventually get to discard one of your ♦ losers on dummy's fourth ♣.

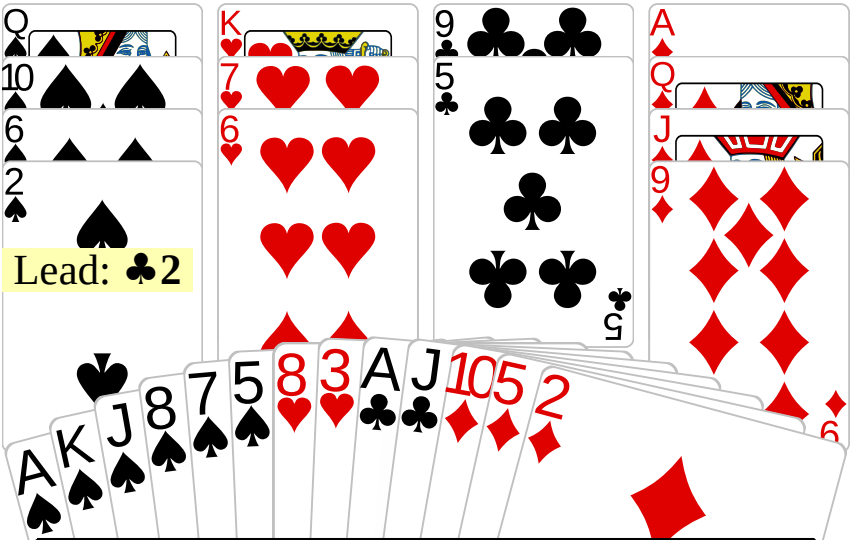
15 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1500 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



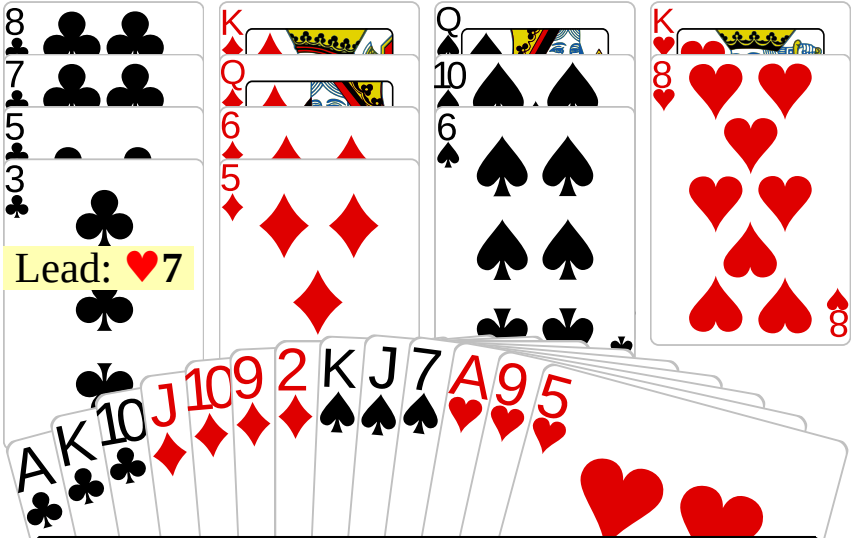
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 2 Ctr: 4♠ Goal: at most ____ losers



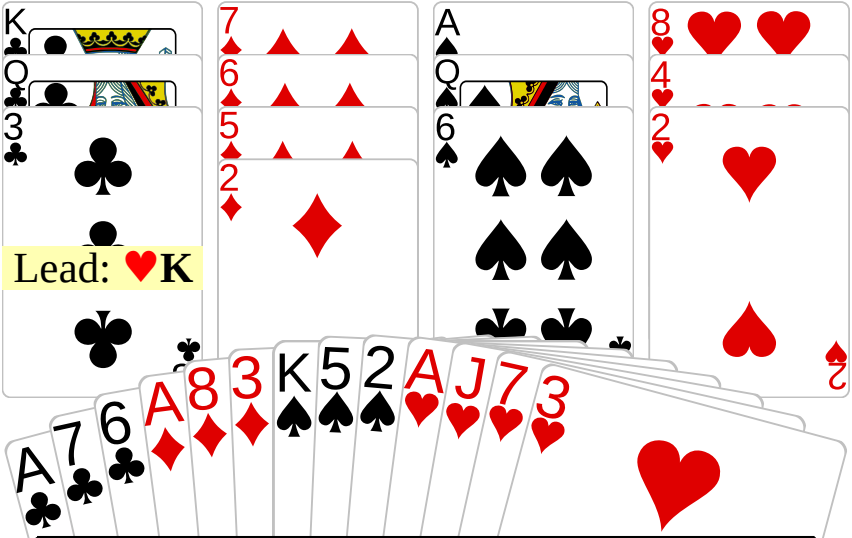
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 3 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 5 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

A

Q

9

7

4

Lead: ♥ J

Q

10

5

9

6

2

Q

5

K

J

8

6

A

J

8

Q

8

4

A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 6 Ctr: 3NT Goal: at least ____ winners

7

5

4

2

♣

Lead: ♥ 6

K

J

10

3

Q

7

4

8

5

K

J

6

A

Q

6

5

A

K

5

A

7

2

Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥4

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣2

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥7

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥K

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥6

Board 1

West Deals

None Vul

♠ J 6

♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6

♦ 10 6 2

♣ 4

♠ A 9 2

♥ A 9 2

♦ K Q 4

♣ A Q 7 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K Q 10 8 3

♥ 4

♦ J 8 7 3

♣ K 5 2

♠ 7 5 4

♥ 5 3

♦ A 9 5

♣ J 10 9 8 3

West

3♥

North

3NT

East

South

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥4

is no need to hold up. But . . . it couldn't hurt, could it?

Yes, it could hurt real bad! Suppose West has nothing in his hand but the ♥ K Q J 10 8 7 6 that you already know about. When you let his ♥10 win the first trick he will realize that his hand is dead. And he may be smart enough, (or lucky enough), to switch to a ♠.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. So the general guideline is to hold up until you are sure one of the defenders is void in the suit - maybe twice, maybe only once, and in this case not at all.

But one of the important considerations you have to think about is the possibility that the Defense will switch to another suit - where you might be in even more trouble.

You'd feel bad on this hand if you let West hold the ♥10 only to see him next lay down the ♠J.

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥4, dummy plays the ♥3 and West the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=1 ♦=3 ♣=1 Total = 6

You may not agree with North's 3NT bid but how else are you going to get to the only game that has a chance of making?

You need 3 extra winners and they will come from the ♣ suit even if East holds the ♣K and wins your finesse. You may think about holding up on the ♥A for one round just to make sure East has none if he wins the ♣K.

That would be a mistake. It is almost certain that West has a 7-card ♥ suit for his preemptive opening. This is confirmed by East's lead of the ♥4, with a doubleton he would have led a higher card. So there

Board 2

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 6 2

♥ K 7 6

♦ A Q J 9

♣ 9 5

♠ 4

♥ A Q 10 2

♦ K 6 4

♣ K 10 8 6 3



♠ A K J 8 7 5

♥ 8 3

♦ 10 5 2

♣ A J

♠ 9 3

♥ J 9 5 4

♦ 8 7 3

♣ Q 7 4 2

West

North

East

South

2 ♣

1 ♣

1 ♠

Pass

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

Lead: ♣ 2

West's 2♣ cue-bid shows a limit-raise or better in ♠s. East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♣2, dummy plays the ♣5 and North the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You have one loser too many. If South holds either the ♥A or the ♦K this will be an easy contract, but North opened the bidding so he probably has most of the high cards. It does look like South holds the ♣Q based on his low lead and North's play to trick one.

Having gone through that thought process what is your Plan?

You will need to discard a loser on dummy's fourth ♦, but you must do so without ever letting South gain the lead since South is the defender who can lead through dummy's ♥K. And the only card that South can get the lead with is the ♣Q.

Hold-ups are usually used in notrump hands, but here you use one to prevent the Danger Hand from gaining the lead. Let North have the ♣K. He cannot play a red card without helping you so he will surely play another ♣.

Pull trumps in two rounds. Then play the ♦10 and let it ride.

North will win this but he is helpless. Whatever he plays you will be able to discard a ♥ loser on dummy's ♦.

The purpose of the hold-up play is to cut communications between the two defenders. Here you knew you would lose exactly one ♣ trick so you chose to lose it to North, the Safe Hand.

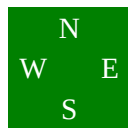
If you had taken the first ♣ trick North would have won your later ♦ finesse, put his partner on lead with the ♣Q and then swallowed up your ♥K.

Of course if South had been clever enough to lead a ♥ originally this Deal wouldn't be here.

Board 3
East Deals
None Vul

♠ 9 5 4 2
♥ 7 3
♦ A 8 4
♣ Q J 9 6

♠ Q 10 6
♥ K 8
♦ K Q 6 5
♣ 8 7 5 3



♠ A 8 3
♥ Q J 10 6 4 2
♦ 7 3
♣ 4 2

♠ K J 7
♥ A 9 5
♦ J 10 9 2
♣ A K 10

West	North	East	South
Pass	3NT	2♥	2NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♥7			

South's 2NT overcall shows a 1NT opening hand with ♥s stopped. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♥7, dummy plays the ♥8 and East the ♥10.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 4

You will need to establish both ♠ and ♦ winners. If East holds both these Aces along with 6 ♥s to the Q J then you are going down. But of course East can't have that good a hand, he opened with a Weak-2. So West has one of the Aces.

If you knew which Ace East held you could make sure you attacked that suit first but unfortunately you have no way of knowing that. So instead you resort to a hold-up. Let East have the first ♥ and win the next ♥ in dummy.

East continues with the ♥Q.

West follows with the ♥3.

Start on ♦s next, maybe because they are longer. Assume that West holds the ♦A and takes it on the third round of the suit.

West glares at you, (because he has no ♥ to lead), and plays the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A. Next you score your ♦ winners and play a ♠, taken by East with the ♠A.

East glares at you, (because you still have the ♥A), and plays another ♥.

You take your 3 tricks and let West have the last ♣.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♦s first you would not have made the contract.

If you did not hold up on the first trick, but established ♠s first you would have made the contract even though you played incorrectly.

If you held up on the first trick you made the contract no matter which Ace West held.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ K 5 2
♥ A J 7 3
♦ A 8 3
♣ A 7 6

♠ 9 4 3

♥ K Q 10 9 5

♦ Q 4

♣ 10 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A Q 6

♥ 8 4 2

♦ 7 6 5 2

♣ K Q 3

♠ J 10 8 7

♥ 6

♦ K J 10 9

♣ J 9 8 4

West

1NT

North

Pass

East

3NT

South

All Pass

3NT by West

Lead: ♥K

North may think that South is encouraging him to continue, just what you want.

Sometimes it works, sometimes it doesn't.

I sure hope that when you play this hand North falls for your Bath Coup.

Because if he doesn't you're going to have to end-play him.

Do you see how that might happen?

West is to play 3NT. North leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and South the ♥6.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 8

You just need one more winner and it could come from the ♦ suit if it happens to split 3-3. But you have another possibility. Suppose you let North hold the first trick and he decides to play another ♥? You would have two ♥ winners.

This isn't a true hold-up play although it does look like one. This play has the rather fancy name of Bath Coup, (named from Bath, England). Presumably North has led from ♥ K Q 10 9 5 and South has played his singleton ♥6. If North realizes that South has played his lowest card he will take that as a discouraging signal and will play a different suit. So you throw out your ♥7 rather than the ♥3. Now

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 7 3
 ♥ K 6 4 3
 ♦ K 7 3 2
 ♣ 5 2

♠ Q 8 4

♥ A 7 2

♦ A J 8

♣ K J 8 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 5

♥ J 10 9 8

♦ 9 6 4

♣ 10 3

♠ 9 6 2

♥ Q 5

♦ Q 10 5

♣ A Q 9 7 4

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♥J

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♥J. You try dummy's ♥Q but West plays the ♥K.

Winners: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=5 Total = 7

Things do not look good. You have only one ♥ stopper, the ♠ suit is wide open, and you have to have the ♦ finesse to get the two extra winners you need.

First problem: Do you hold up the ♥A or not?

No, don't hold up. If you do they might take 4 ♠ tricks immediately, then go back to ♥s. Since your only hope of making this contract is the ♦ finesse you should grab the ♥A, play 5 rounds of ♣s then finesse for the ♦K.

Or not.

Remember: don't hold up when it gives the defenders a good opportunity to switch.

Board 6

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ Q 7 4
 ♥ 8 5
 ♦ K J 10 3
 ♣ 7 5 4 2

♠ J 10 8 2
 ♥ Q 10 4
 ♦ 9 7
 ♣ A 10 8 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K 5
 ♥ A 7 2
 ♦ A Q 6 5
 ♣ K J 6

♠ 9 6 3
 ♥ K J 9 6 3
 ♦ 8 4 2
 ♣ Q 9

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
		2NT	Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♥6

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♥6, dummy plays the ♥5 and North the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=1 ♦=4 ♣=0 Total = 8

Needing only one more winner you decide to hold up on the first ♥ and also the ♥ continuation. You take your ♥A on the third round, South having used the ♥3 to drive out your ♥A.

North returns the ♥10.

South wins with the ♥J and continues with the ♥3; dummy discards a ♣ and North plays the ♥4.

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when North plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

You need one trick from the ♣ suit, so you win 4 ♦ tricks, then the ♠A, ♠Q, putting you in dummy. Next you play a ♣ from dummy, and when North plays low you put on . . . which ♣?

This is not a guess. If South has the ♣A he will get the lead and when he does he will set you with 2 more ♥ tricks. So you assume that North has the ♣A and play your ♣K.

This is a lesson about holding up, and if you had not held up twice in ♥s you would certainly have gone down.

But it's not enough to just be smart enough to hold up, you must also be able to figure out how to make the best plays later as well.